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Many CPD officers barred from testifying

As a legal fight stalls the police discipline process, local prosecutors have disqualified accused cops from being called as witnesses in criminal cases

By **Sam Charles**
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

For three years, Chicago police officers accused of serious misconduct have had to sit and wait for the Illinois Supreme Court to decide the future of officer discipline.

Bad cops are not being fired, and good cops who may be wrongfully

accused are stuck in professional purgatory.

And as the city and the Fraternal Order of Police await resolution in the yearslong legal fight, records reviewed by the Tribune show local prosecutors have disqualified dozens of current Chicago Police Department officers from testifying in criminal cases, even as their disci-

plinary matters remain pending.

In response to a Freedom of Information Act request, the state's attorney's office disclosed that 254 law enforcement officers in Cook County will not be called as witnesses for the prosecution following changes to office policy enacted last year. Of those, 240 work or have worked for CPD.

The Police Department has moved to fire 27 of the officers, records show. Most of those cases remain on hold pending a ruling from the Illinois Supreme Court,

expected later this year, and those 27 officers were placed on no-pay status after the administrative charges were filed.

The list of officers barred from testifying ballooned from just 66 in March 2023 to 290 in October 2024, shortly before then-Cook County State's Attorney Kim Foxx left office. Meanwhile, city employment records show at least 87 officers — ranging from blue-shirt beat cops to detectives to supervisors — have either retired or resigned from the department “under

inquiry” since 2024.

The following year, in December 2025, State's Attorney Eileen O'Neill Burke's office updated the policy to add an officer to the list after receiving a notification that the officer was stripped of police powers. A CPD spokesperson said the state's attorney's office is notified every month of officers who are in that category.

Witnesses for the prosecution also are required to fill out a questionnaire, disclosing “to the best of

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Teens look over the collectible cards they received at the National Sports Collectors Convention in the Donald E. Stephens Convention Center in Rosemont on Friday. The five-day event drew dealers and collectors from across the country. **ANTONIO PEREZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

‘CRUSHING IT’

Baseball cards are worth more than ever. And kids are making a fortune

By **Lila Hempel-Edgers** | CHICAGO TRIBUNE

The movers and shakers strolling through Rosemont aren't your normal power brokers. Some still have braces. Others observe a strict bedtime.

But don't be fooled. The children working deals at this year's National Sports Collectors Convention control inventories worth more than many adults earn in a year.

“Kids literally have a down payment on a house in their case,” said Zach Grygier, a 29-year-old sports card dealer. “They can't even drive a car and they have a down payment on a house.”

The National returned to the northwest suburb last week, drawing hundreds of dealers and tens of thousands of collectors from across the country for five days of buying, selling and trading sports cards and memorabilia. It marked the convention's 16th appearance in the Chicago area and its first consecutive return to the same venue in 43 years.

Amid the latest sports card boom, the industry is projected to grow from roughly \$15 billion to more than \$50 billion over the next decade. In a country packed with card shows, big and small, the National is both the Super Bowl and the World Cup of collecting.

Lines formed hours before the doors opened each day, with attendees stretching nearly a mile down North River Road. The crowd skewed younger than ever before, said Ronnie Holloway, a lifelong collector who owns sports card shops in North Center and Belmont Cragin.

“The pandemic brought a younger generation alive,”

Holloway, 57, said. “You can compare the sports card industry to COVID-19 because that's how fast it spread, and it just kept getting bigger and bigger and bigger.”

But this isn't the hobby's first boom. What began with children ripping open packs stuffed with stale sticks of gum had grown into a billion-dollar industry by the 1990s. Overproduction and loose licensing practices then gutted the market, slashing annual sales to the low millions and ushering in what collectors came to call the junk wax era.

Today's resurgence has

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Trump to pause strikes on Iran again

Talks by allies to end fighting take shape, president announces

By **Aamer Madhani**
and **Samy Magdy**
ASSOCIATED PRESS

WASHINGTON — President Donald Trump says he will order U.S. forces to hold off on new strikes against Iran, claiming Mideast allies have reached the parameters of a deal to end the 5-month-old war.

Trump said Sunday that a plan was in place for U.S. forces to carry out “the biggest attack since World War II” on Sunday. But he decided to scrap the plan and give diplomacy more time to play out after hearing from key Gulf leaders.

The emerging deal “would include the Immediate, Complete, and Total OPENING OF THE HORMUZ STRAIT, and an end to Iran's nuclear threat” Trump wrote in a Saturday evening social media post.

“Based on this request, I have agreed, for the future benefit of the WORLD and, likewise, the survival of a successful and prosperous Iran, to cancel the attack, subject to being able to rapidly make a DEAL,” Trump said.

However, Iran's Foreign Ministry spokesperson Esmail Baghaei said Sunday that the Strait of Hormuz “will in no way return to the status it was before February 28th,” the day the war started.

On a call with Iranian state TV, he added that Iran is discussing shipping through the strait with Oman, on the other side of Hormuz, but that there's no talk about reopening the waterway.

Trump has announced halts to strikes in Iran on several occasions since the United States and Israel attacked Iran on Feb. 28, only for things to unravel and fighting to resume again.

Iran's defense minister said on X that the country was “neither

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Illinois Secretary of State Giannoulias announces run for Chicago mayor

By **Jake Sheridan**
and **Alice Yin**
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Illinois Secretary of State Alexi Giannoulias announced Sunday he will run for mayor of Chicago, ending over a year of speculation and making official his frontrunner status in the already-crowded field.

Giannoulias entered the race buoyed by high name recognition, support from trade unions and a towering lead in campaign cash. He announced his campaign at a rally inside the International Brotherhood of Electrical Workers Local 134 headquarters in Bronzeville, joined by a cadre of support-



Secretary of State Alexi Giannoulias greets people during a Democratic Party brunch at the Illinois State Fair in August 2025 in Springfield.

DOMINIC DI PALERMO/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

ers from the City Council, trade unions and the business community.

The flashy, made-for-TV rollout sought to emphasize themes of Chicago patriotism, as well as Giannoulias' ties to small busi-

nesses across town and to former President Barack Obama.

After playing a slideshow to the tune of “Vivir Mi Vida,” Giannoulias launched into a

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EILEEN T. MESLAR/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Lollapalooza wraps up

Mara Smith, from left, Sarah Henry and Christina Austin dance as Amber Mark performs at Lollapalooza in Grant Park on Sunday, the final day of the festival. **Coverage in Chicagoland and Arts & Living**

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